

Description & Eligibility

Contestants will assess career readiness and professional communication through the job search, interview, and portfolio presentation process. Contestants will prepare a resume, cover letter, and professional portfolio demonstrating their skills, experiences, and accomplishments. Participants will research career qualifications, present a professional image, and participate in an advanced interview scenario in an in-person format. Evaluation will emphasize professionalism, portfolio quality, communication effectiveness, and understanding of ethical workplace practices. Any secondary or postsecondary division contestant may enter this judged event. Contestants may *not* enter both Interview Skills and Advanced Interview Skills in the same year. Advanced Interview Skills may be repeated. Contestants must be registered for the national competition before the submission deadline and compete in both parts of the event to be ranked.

Contestant Must Supply

- Paper portfolio no larger than 8 1/2" x 11" in plastic sheet protectors or electronic portfolios may be displayed on a notebook/laptop computer or tablet
- One (1) copy of your resume and cover letter submitted at presentation check-in (both preliminaries and finals)

Contest Notes

- Method of evaluation: judged
- AI Policy Level 1 *No AI Allowed*
- No Internet access will be provided on-site at NLC; however, contestants may provide their own mobile device only as a hotspot to access their digital portfolio. The device(s) must be set up prior to entering the presentation room
- No time will be given for the setup of equipment and must be done solely by the contestant
- Portfolio will not be submitted; the contestant will take the portfolio into the interview to be used to demonstrate job competence. Portfolios must not be left with judges
 - At NLC, contestants will take the Professional Communications certification exam. Contestants passing this certification will have 50 points added to their event score. A Pearson profile must be created at <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com> before attending NLC
 - Contestants must include their BPA Contestant ID in their Pearson profile when they register
 - Certiport Parent/Legal Guardian Consent Form must be uploaded to: education@bpa.org
 - For more information on the exam, visit <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com>
 - Reference materials are not allowed for certification testing
 - No more than fifty (50) minutes for certification test
- Length of event: no more than fifteen (15) minutes for interview
- Finals may be part of the competition

Technical Pre-Submit Specifications

What to Submit at https://upload.bpa.org	Saved File Name(s)	National Deadline
Submit one combined PDF file: 1. Resume 2. Cover Letter	AIS-ContestantID-pdf	April 1, 2027, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time

Contest Competencies

1. Create a tailored Applicant Tracking System (ATS) optimized résumé, cover letter, and a professional portfolio showcasing skills, accomplishments, and qualifications
2. Demonstrate strong employability and career advancement skills including adaptability, initiative, and continuous learning
3. Research career opportunities, industry trends, credentials, and expectations for professional image and branding
4. Communicate respectfully and ethically in diverse work environments, demonstrating integrity and effective collaboration with others
5. Exhibit advanced interview communication skills through persuasive storytelling, situational awareness, and confident interpersonal interaction
6. Demonstrate professionalism when discussing salary, benefits, and job offers
7. Use networking skills to build professional connections through career events, organizations, and personal interactions
8. Demonstrate advanced interviewing skills by giving clear, confident answers to interview and judge questions, and using examples to explain skills and experiences

Contest Specifications for this Event

- Business cards, thank you notes, etc. are not permitted
- Contestant will indicate on his/her resume the position for which he/she is applying. There are openings in all departments of Digital Solutions shown on the Organizational Chart found in the *Style & Reference Manual*
- Resume work/volunteer history must be in reverse chronological order
- Contestant may interview for any position listed on the organizational chart for which he/she is qualified
- Contestants that do not apply for a position for one of these positions will be disqualified
- Information in the cover letter and resume must be authentic; however, contestants may choose to use a fictitious personal address and telephone number. The use of references on the resume is optional.
- The cover letter must be addressed as follows:
 - Ms. Julie Smith, Manager
Human Resources Department
Digital Solutions
1365 King Avenue
Columbus, OH 43212



Common Specifications for all BPA Judged Events

- This is a pre-submitted event. Regional and state conferences have specific deadlines prior to the national deadlines. Please consult the regional or state conference administrator for those deadlines. For the National Leadership Conference, submit project files at <https://upload.bpa.org> no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time on April 1, 2027.
- An auto-generated confirmation will be provided upon project submission for the National Leadership Conference; individual confirmation cannot be provided. No changes can be made to the project after the date of submission.
- Contestant ID is required for all submissions. Materials from non-registered contestants and/or those missing Contestant ID cannot be accepted.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will not be returned and will not be available at NLC.

730 Advanced Interview Skills

Technical Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Materials indicate contestant applied for one of the positions shown on the Organizational Chart of Digital Solutions found in the <i>Style & Reference Manual</i> .				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to the question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Submission and Formatting (All points or none are awarded by the technical judge)				
Contestant submitted their Cover Letter and Resume in one (1) combined PDF file.				/10
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-3 points	Meets Expectations 4-7 points	Above Expectations 8-10 points	Points Awarded
Cover Letter				
Introduction and Address	Introduction is missing or vague, lacks clarity or relevance.	Somewhat engaging but lacks specificity or impact.	Engaging and specific, effectively captures attention.	/10
Relevance of Skills	Skills are not relevant to the position or not mentioned at all.	Some relevant skills are mentioned but may not be clearly tied to the position or fully explained.	All skills are clearly relevant to the position, well-explained, and directly applicable to the requirements.	/10
Closing Statement	Missing or ineffective; fails to summarize key points.	Basic closing present but lacks impact.	Strong, compelling summary; leaves a memorable impression.	/10
Writing Accuracy	Numerous errors impacting clarity.	Few errors, minor impact on clarity.	Error-free, polished grammar and spelling.	/10
Layout and Formatting	Poorly organized, difficult to read, lacks visual appeal.	Adequate organization, readable, lacks consistency.	Well-organized, enhances readability and visual appeal.	/10
Resume				
Job Position Listed	Position not listed or listing unclear.	Position listed but not effectively highlighted.	Clearly listed at the top, prominently highlights target role.	/10
Layout and Formatting	Poorly organized, difficult to read, lacks visual appeal.	Adequate organization, readable, lacks consistency.	Well-organized, enhances readability and visual appeal.	/10
Order of Work History	Not in reverse chronological order, challenging understanding.	Mostly in reverse chronological order, with some inconsistencies.	Completely in reverse chronological order, facilitating clear career progression.	/10
Writing Accuracy	Numerous errors impacting clarity.	Few errors, minor impact on clarity.	Error-free, polished grammar and spelling.	/10
TOTAL TECHNICAL POINTS				/100

730 Advanced Interview Skills

Presentation Scoring Rubric

Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-20 points	Above Expectations 21-30	Points Awarded
First Impressions	Poor introduction; lacked positive first impression.	Adequate introduction; made a somewhat positive first impression.	Strong introduction; made a very positive first impression.	/30
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-7 points	Meets Expectations 8-14 points	Above Expectations 15-20 points	Points Awarded
Applicant's Appearance	Not neat or well-groomed; inappropriate attire.	Somewhat neat and well-groomed; acceptable attire.	Neat, well-groomed, and appropriately attired.	/20
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-20 points	Above Expectations 21-30	Points Awarded
Personality and Poise	Negative or insincere demeanor; poor posture and eye contact.	Generally positive and courteous; acceptable posture and eye contact.	Positive, courteous, sincere, confident; good posture and eye contact.	/30
Communication Skills	Poor grammar and pronunciation; unpleasant voice and tone.	Acceptable grammar and pronunciation; generally pleasant voice and tone.	Proper grammar and pronunciation; pleasant voice and tone.	/30
Skills & Qualifications	Lacking required job skills, work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	Demonstrated some required job skills, work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	Demonstrated strong job skills, good work habits, and problem-solving abilities.	/30
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-39 points	Meets Expectations 40-79 points	Above Expectations 80-100 points	Points Awarded
Judges' Questions	Inadequate answers: little to no knowledge of the position or company; lack of initiative.	Acceptable answers: some knowledge of the position and company; demonstrated some initiative.	Appropriate and informed answers; good knowledge of the position and company; demonstrated initiative and enthusiasm.	/100
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-20 points	Above Expectations 21-30	Points Awarded
Final Impressions	Failed to express thanks or conclude the interview effectively.	Adequately expressed thanks and concluded the interview.	Expressed thanks and concluded the interview effectively.	/30
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-7 points	Meets Expectations 8-14 points	Above Expectations 15-20 points	Points Awarded
Portfolio	Poorly organized; minimal relevant information.	Adequately organized; some relevant information.	Well-organized; relevant and diverse information.	/20
Documentation	One (1) copy of the Cover Letter and Résumé was submitted at presentation check-in (both preliminaries and finals).			/10
TOTAL INTERVIEW POINTS				/300

Note: no more than fifteen (15) minutes for interview.